

Point of no return

First, to conclude the cliffhanger of last month's column: I've made it back safely, much to the team's chagrin, and Malaysian Airlines and Boeing 777-200s aren't bad at all.

Before I left on my trip down under, some of us from Digit attended an off-site meeting organised by our company. An off-site, for those who don't already know, is when employees of a company get away to a location away from work and home, get together and work on team building and improving various aspects of themselves and the company.

Amongst a lot of planning, tests, skill improvement exercises and even cricket matches, was a simple exercise to just close your eyes and sit still in silence for 10 minutes with an absolutely empty mind, thinking of nothing at all. Sounds easy? Try it.

I have never failed so miserably in something my entire life as I did this simple exercise. I just couldn't do it, and my mind was wandering and latching on to so many random thoughts at once - wondering whether the issue had reached stands, how my son was getting along without me, whether I had any messages from my wife and wondering how many emails from readers I would have to catch up on afterwards... it was just insane. I even started thinking of story ideas at one point, and felt like I was falling because I couldn't stand the blankness. It's become almost impossible to just switch off any more, because I'm so used to being always on, always connected, always alert.

I'm not alone though. For example, when the net connection is disrupted at office, all of a sudden the whole team is abuzz, wondering what happened, testing various sites, running ping commands and ipconfigs, changing gateways and DNS servers. I have seen even those getting up to take a coffee break sit back down to try and figure out the mystery of dead connection. Riveted to their seats as if watching Hitchcock's finest work, asking "Who killed it, and will we ever find out why?" I should add, I also behave exactly the same, at home or office.

The same happens when the electricity goes out, or the batteries of our phones or gadgets are running low. How many times have you frantically looked for charging ports as soon as your battery is under 10/20 per cent? There's an entire market built around this paranoia - portable chargers.

In fact even when we're all juiced up, everything's working as it should and there's no problems in sight, we sometimes find ourselves looking at our phones just to ensure everything's OK. "No Facebook updates in the last 5 minutes? Is my data plan working?" <turns mobile network off and on just in case>.

Although billions still live everyday life without technology, it's not out of choice. I know we all like to believe that we can choose to live without tech, or even electricity, for that matter, but can we? I doubt it.

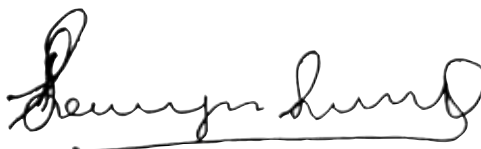
Science and technology is helping us improve everything. Not only do we live longer thanks to it (as our cover story this month will outline), but we also have a better quality of life. Yes, technology, like any other tool, can do us both good or harm, depending on whether we use or abuse it. Think of it as a crutch filled with cocaine - we can choose to use the crutch and focus on walking, or use the cocaine and get addicted to going nowhere.

It's easy to choose the latter use of technology, and get addicted to, for example: apps, games, pointless Facebook surfing, 9gag, reddit-ing away your life, watching videos all day long and aimlessly looking at memes (all of the above are fine as short leisure activities).

This will always be the majority use for all technology - pure entertainment, and it's funny that the addicts are perhaps the people who will survive without technology as well, if it came to that. They'd just get another fix from somewhere else.

However, there will also always be those who use technology to not just consume but create as well, and push the limits. It's these people who have accepted technology so openly that they cannot live without it, because they're done being fascinated by it, and it's now a crutch they depend on to walk.

I think it's safe for us to assume that any Digit reader sits squarely in the category of creators who cannot function without technology anymore. We're all way past the point of no return, and technology has become an essential ingredient of life for us, and we wouldn't have it any other way. Would we? 




Robert Sovereign-Smith
Executive Editor
robert@thinkdigit.com

"I know we all like to believe that we can choose to live without tech, or even electricity, for that matter, but can we? I doubt it"

Liked or hated this column?
Write in to
robert@thinkdigit.com
and let me know your thoughts.